

The on-field team of Saamya recognizes the harmful behaviors exhibited by boys, often learned from their surroundings and works towards addressing the root causes. The observations from the field experience say that many boys expressed feelings of hurt and grief through concealed anger and resentment, often learned from their fathers. This behavior was further solidified through the confirmation bias perpetuated by movies and external influences, which glorify the "alpha" and "macho" man. Sessions like "It's Okay to Cry" and "Power of Words" focus on helping boys understand and express their emotions, challenging stereotypes, and promoting healthier expressions of masculinity.

To assess the impact of the pilot initiative, an outcome review was conducted by Dr. Malika Singh, a gender professional with 35 years of experience, in August 2023. She had previously served as the director at Sahay for eight years before transitioning to work as an independent consultant and seasoned gender specialist. Her assessment revealed that the program effectively influenced the behavior of boys, steering them towards a gender-positive and sensitive approach. There exists a fundamental understanding of gender and the resulting discrimination among the participants. Dr. Singh evaluated the 40-session module on the ground, finding it highly effective. Feedback from children, along with input from parents, siblings, teachers, and other stakeholders, confirmed its impact. A notable reduction in anger and abusive language was observed, significantly benefiting the lives of the beneficiaries.

Mothers, in particular, attribute these positive changes to Saamya. Additionally, it was discovered that boys have begun actively participating in household chores alongside their mothers and sisters, inspired by discussions on the unfair distribution of labor. This sets a noteworthy example for the younger siblings. Aspects not apparent in quantitative discussions became evident during focused group discussions and one-on-one interviews with the children. These insights were then curated into impactful stories. The discussions also delved into gender-specific behaviors such as eve-teasing and societal gender expectations. An excerpt from one of the impact stories illustrates this point.

One of the boys at Saamya said, "I have been greatly influenced and inspired by the gender sessions because films have harmed me. I observed that when the hero proposed to the heroine, he teased the girl, and she accepted his proposal. For a long time, I believed this to be true. However, during a Children's Cabinet session, Didi explained the difference and helped in changing my perspective. Fairness cream advertisements are also very misleading, suggesting that a fair girl will marry sooner."

Saamya also successfully countered the external factors on the boys' perceptions of gender roles and expectations. By addressing misleading messages from films and advertisements, Saamya empowers boys to question discriminatory practices and think critically about changing societal norms.

The initiative recognizes that gender, as a standalone identity expression, should not be a tool for discrimination and subjugation. Instead, boys are seen as agents through which power structures like patriarchy operate. Saamya encourages boys to question these structures and work towards a more equitable future.





DS Group's Saamya initiative stands out as a transformative effort to foster gender equity by sensitizing young boys. By intervening at an early age and addressing the root causes of gender-related issues, Saamya aims to create a lasting impact on societal norms. The success stories and positive outcomes underscore the significance of such interventions, emphasizing the potential for transformative change at the grassroots level.